

What is the actual margin of difference of environmental damage between just anything else vs using AI (ChatGPT etc)

Posted by u/Impressive-Bill-3467 • 0 points • 5 comments

I've been seeing a lot of people angry at others for using ChatGPT and any AI (even for simple prompts) because they say it wastes water. But maybe I'm ignorant but in my head it feels like it doesn't make sense or that our factories/other industrial or technological use similarly wastes water as well, hence the social externalities of using AI should be marginal? Idk educate me please 🙄

Comments

u/notextinctyet • 1 points • 2026-02-09 08:04 UTC

We use water in industrial and agricultural processes to create value for society. AI, and also crypto, consume a lot of water. Crypto definitely doesn't deliver value to society. AI may or may not, depending on what you're using it for.

Some people feel that AI never or almost never delivers any real value, or even that it does active harm to creators or is/should be illegal. So any environmental damage on top of that is just destruction for destruction's sake, like crypto. Some people feel that AI does deliver value to society and so the water and energy usage is worth it in the same way that any other industrial process is.

u/Arvidex • 1 points • 2026-02-09 06:55 UTC

[This](https://youtu.be/5sFBySzNIX0?si=YmOAYwEYiDtTn_h7) is a great video by environmental scientist Dr. Simon Clarke explaining it in a good but not too complicated amount of detail.

u/BadUpper • 2 points • 2026-02-09 04:24 UTC

Analogy:

If John starts a forest fire, that's a problem bc it fucks up the environment and uses all kinds of resources to put out. He should be held accountable for that; but for whatever reason, his accountability has slipped through the cracks and he was never blamed. That does not mean that Jane can now start a forest fire of a similar size and claim that just because John does it, it's not so bad if she does too.

Also, John's fire was started because he was grilling on dry grass (he needed to eat) and was negligent about the sparks flying. Still bad, still to blame, still should've been held accountable. However, Jane just thinks burning forests down is kinda fun and it sometimes makes it easier to get through the woods since the trees are gone.

u/Patient-Weakness-562 • 2 points • 2026-02-09 04:09 UTC

the water usage stuff is real but yeah you're right that it's pretty small compared to like crypto mining or just regular data centers - most estimates put a chatgpt conversation at maybe a water bottle's worth which honestly feels less wasteful than half the stuff we do daily

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 1 points • 2026-02-09 04:40 UTC

> most estimates put a chatgpt conversation at maybe a water bottle's worth which honestly feels less wasteful than half the stuff we do daily

Can you link that estimate? Because i believe that's still way off and more like 1% of that. I have seen power estimates and it's like in the 100s to 1000s of Watt, there is no way any hardware would use a whole bottle of water to cool that.